Music Mind Theory - Project Proposal

Enhancing Music-Induced Emotions: The Role of Extramusical Contextual Narratives

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1 Objective and Aims

Building on established work in music psychology and findings by Vuoskoski and Eerola (2013)[3], this project aims to investigate the impact of extramusical contextual narratives on the emotional experience induced by music.

Specifically, we plan to widen the scope of the study by analysing how varying different narrative contexts (e.g., emotionally congruent, neutral, or incongruent descriptions) modulate the affective responses to the same musical excerpt.

By employing a series of indirect emotion-measuring tasks (such as word recall and affect-congruent judgment tasks), which have shown to reliably measure felt emotion [2].

2 Motivation and Theoretical Framework

While music's capacity to evoke strong emotions has been extensively studied, the influence of extramusical, narrative context relatively underexplored. Vuoskoski and Eerola's (2013)[3] work demonstrates that contextual information—when paired with music—can shape and even amplify the listener's emotional experience by promoting vivid, imagery-driven narratives.

However, the experiment primarily focused on a narrow set of musical and narrative stimuli (often limited to sad music), used with sad or neutral stimuli.

Another issue with the previous study was that it compared the effect of narrative descriptions on emotion by contrasting new word recall results with data from an earlier experiment[4]. We propose to address this by conducting a unified experiment with appropriate control groups to verify these effects.

3 Methodology

We tried to reproduce the same experimental conditions as the previous[3], but changed the groups and narratives. We also removed the empathy related measures in the experiment, since we are not interested in those values in our experiment.

- Participants are tested individually in separate rooms or one by one. We will be using a microsoft form to collect the responses for the tests, but music itself will be played separately in a music player like VLC.
- They complete the initial PANAS[5], with the PANAS adjectives presented in a counterbalanced order.
- Participants listen to the music excerpt through studio-quality headphones (same across all) and adjust the volume as needed.

- Immediately after listening, they perform a 2-minute word recall task, writing down as many adjectives from the initial PANAS as they can remember.
- Next, they complete the picture judgment task[1], rating 25 composite facial expressions on a 1–7 scale.
- Participants then complete a second PANAS, provide free-response descriptions of their thoughts during the music listening, and rate how much they like the music.
- The entire session is plan to last approximately 25 minutes, after which participants are debriefed and compensated

For analyzing the results we plan on using one-way ANOVAs to compare affective state and emotion ratings across conditions and also perform paired t-tests on word recall scores. The original paper uses two-way ANOVA and other correlation methods but we plan on keeping it relatively simple.

4 Hypothesis

Given prior findings on the role of extramusical narratives in shaping emotional experiences, we predict that providing listeners with contextually meaningful narratives will enhance their affective engagement with music. Specifically, we test the following hypotheses:

- $\mathbf{H_0}$: All music listeners perform equally.
- $\mathbf{H_1}$: Listeners given a *congruent* narrative perform better.
- $\mathbf{H_2}$: Listeners given both *congruent* and *incongruent* narratives outperform those with no narrative or a control condition.

References

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